

SAFFRON SHOWER
Amit Shah with Suvendu Adhikari and Rashbehari seat candidate Swapan Dasgupta at a roadshow in Kolkata, Apr. 2

that year, Shah launched an ambitious membership drive in Bengal—the 'Sadasyata Abhiyan' set a target of 10 million new members by January 15, 2026. They didn't meet the target—party sources says the number hovers around 8 million currently—but the exercise yielded something more significant—a structured hierarchy of engagement.

Anyone who could enrol 100 primary members was designated an active member. Today, the party claims to have 60,000 such active members. This tiered structure ensured accountability and local ownership. The drive was executed in phases under different leaders. Rajya Sabha MP and current state president Samik Bhattacharya initially led the effort, followed by former Union minister of state Subhas Sarkar, and later state vice-president Prabal Raha.

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The leadership consciously fostered competition. During the drive, those involved were required to report their numbers every night at 10 pm via video conference. Central leaders, including Bansal, monitored these sessions closely. His style, sources say, was "calibrated". In one meeting, Bansal reportedly remarked that he was "*kukhyat* (notorious)" in his native Uttar Pradesh for cutting out non-performers. The message was clear. Performance would determine one's chances within the organisation. Sarkar frames it a tad more diplomatically: "The leadership instilled a sense of competition among the workers. And it showed results."

Simultaneously, key leaders like Adhikari, an ex-TMC strongman himself, were assigned responsibility over the 'shakti kendras', micro organisational units similar to a panchayat samiti. They travelled extensively, holding meetings and energising the cadre.

Factionalism was one area where the central leadership directly intervened, asking leaders to set aside differences and project a united front. The change is visible on the ground. Former state chief and Sangh veteran Dilip Ghosh, once at odds with Adhikari, was present at his nomination rally in Nandigram.